

MIG-20

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-20

Age: 40

Gender: Male

Country of origin: Ukraine

Host country: Poland

Years in host country: 3

Occupation: IT Specialist

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I came to Poland three years ago when the war forced my family to flee Ukraine, uprooting us suddenly and completely from the life we had built. We left almost everything behind as our city came under threat, taking only what we could carry and not knowing if we would ever return or what we would find if we did. Poland, our immediate neighbour, opened its doors to Ukrainian refugees with remarkable generosity in those first terrible weeks. Though I am deeply grateful for the refuge we were given, leaving my homeland under such tragic and violent circumstances was genuinely devastating for me and for my entire family, a grief and a rupture that we are all still processing and that shapes everything about our lives here now.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being able to work in my own profession and to rebuild our lives with dignity intact, rather than being seen and defined permanently as war refugees, as objects of pity marked forever by the catastrophe that displaced us. It shows itself when Poles accept us as neighbours, colleagues, and fellow members of the community rather than as a temporary burden to be tolerated. Belonging, for me, is the feeling that we have a real and secure place here, that we are contributing our skills and participating fully, even as we continue to hope for peace and for the eventual chance to return to the home we were forced to leave behind, holding both realities at once.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: Initially, Poles were extraordinarily and movingly welcoming to Ukrainian refugees, driven by a genuine solidarity rooted in our shared history and our common experience of Russian aggression, and that warmth meant everything in those first desperate days. However, as the war has dragged on far longer than anyone hoped, some fatigue and occasional tension have understandably emerged, particularly around competition for resources, housing, and jobs. While what we face is far less than what migrants from more distant regions and different backgrounds encounter, we have nonetheless met with some resentment as the initial powerful wave of goodwill has gradually diminished somewhat with time and with the sheer prolongation of the crisis and its costs.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The main challenges were the deep trauma of fleeing an active war, the sudden and total upheaval of our entire lives, and the profound uncertainty about our future and about what would become of the home and country we left behind. Despite the genuine linguistic similarities between Ukrainian and Polish, which certainly helped, the process of professional integration and of navigating a new country's systems and bureaucracy still took real effort and adjustment. But the heaviest burden by far has been the emotional weight of displacement itself, combined with the constant worry and grief for those we love who remained in Ukraine, living under threat, which no amount of practical success here can fully lift or resolve.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: In the IT sector my skills are genuinely valued, and the working environment is international, professional, and welcoming, which has made my integration considerably smoother than it has been for many other refugees in different fields. My Polish colleagues have been supportive, decent, and professional, and my technical expertise largely transcends the language barrier, since code and technical problems are much the same everywhere. Working in technology has been a real fortune in this respect, because the industry values talent, competence, and results regardless of nationality or background, which has allowed me to rebuild a professional life relatively quickly and to regain some of the stability and sense of purpose that the war so violently took from me.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I maintain my Ukrainian identity strongly, and if anything more strongly now than ever before, through my language, my culture, and my active solidarity with my homeland during this time of terrible trial and suffering. The genuine similarities between Ukrainian and Polish culture ease my integration and create a sense of familiarity, and I have come to appreciate Poland deeply and sincerely for its extraordinary hospitality toward us in our hour of need. I feel Ukrainian to my very core, in my heart and my identity, while being genuinely grateful to and increasingly connected with Poland, the country that took my family in and gave us safety when we had nowhere else to turn.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: Media coverage of Ukrainian refugees has been largely sympathetic and supportive here in Poland, reflecting the genuine solidarity that most Poles have felt toward us given our shared history and the nature of the war we fled. This positive and humane portrayal has significantly helped our acceptance and our ability to build lives here. However, I am painfully aware that this warm welcome contrasts sharply with how migrants and refugees from other regions and backgrounds are so often treated, which raises uncomfortable and important questions about why some refugees receive so much more compassion, sympathy, and practical support than others who are fleeing equally desperate circumstances and are equally deserving of basic human solidarity.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: The support for Ukrainian refugees in Poland was genuinely remarkable, especially at the outset, with government programmes, vast volunteer efforts, and spontaneous community assistance all mobilising with extraordinary speed and generosity to help us. That outpouring of solidarity was deeply

moving and I will never forget it. The integration support, ranging from help finding work to enrolling our children in local schools, was among the best and most comprehensive I have ever seen or heard of, reflecting the exceptional goodwill toward Ukrainians during this crisis. It stands, in my mind, as an example of what is genuinely possible when a society chooses to respond to refugees with open arms rather than with fear.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: My children are adapting well, learning Polish quickly, helped by the similarity to Ukrainian, and attending local schools where they are settling in and making friends, which brings me tremendous relief amid all the upheaval and loss we have experienced. I do worry about the trauma they carry from the war and the sudden flight, and I hope very much that they can maintain their Ukrainian identity and language even as they integrate here. Whether we ultimately return home or remain in Poland, I want them to grow up as proud Ukrainians, resilient and grounded despite the war that displaced them, carrying their heritage forward whatever the future holds for our family and our country.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, the remarkable solidarity that has been shown to Ukrainians demonstrates clearly what is genuinely possible when a society chooses compassion and openness over fear and suspicion. That very same empathy, I firmly believe, should be extended to all refugees, regardless of their origin, their religion, or the colour of their skin, because the human need for safety is universal. Recognising our shared humanity, providing real and practical support, and fostering genuine community connections between newcomers and locals are what transform fear into acceptance, and this is true for everyone fleeing hardship, violence, and war, not only for those who happen to resemble the host population.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope above all for peace in Ukraine, so that my family might one day return home to help rebuild our country and our lives there, though we remain deeply grateful for the refuge that Poland has given us in the meantime. If we do end up staying, I hope to continue my career and to contribute meaningfully to the country that welcomed us. But most of all, and most deeply, I dream of the day when the war finally ends and my homeland is free, safe, and whole once again, when the threat is lifted and the people I love can live without fear, and when the terrible wound of this war can at last begin to heal.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to fellow refugees is to accept the help that is offered to you graciously and without shame, while also working steadily to rebuild your own independence and dignity, because both receiving support and regaining self-reliance have their place. Make full use of your professional skills, which often transcend borders and can help you rebuild more quickly than you might expect. Learn the local language to integrate and connect. Support your community and actively maintain your identity, especially in these hard times when it matters most. And, through everything, hold onto hope for your homeland while building a real and stable life in safety, because you can do both at once.